

Golden Age . . . Sports Writing Colorful Or Undisciplined?

By CHARLES MAHER
The Los Angeles Times

Famous writers by the hundreds have covered athletic events by the thousands and written words by the millions since sports got a page of their own in the daily paper. But only one of the typewriters used to assemble that massive product has been selected for display at the College Football Hall of Fame.

It belonged to the late Grantland Rice, who wrote probably the best-remembered sports story of them all.

Rice was still writing as recently as the '50s but was more closely identified with an earlier period. It embraced the so-called Golden Age of American sports and was distinguished, some believe, by the best, or at least most colorful, of American sports writing.

The recent enshrinement of Rice's typewriter got an editor to thinking. Was sports writing in general all that good back then? Was much of it really colorful, or just undisciplined? He suggested taking a look, going back to the '20s and before.

First stop: 1928. And a story about an ailing ballplayer in a big game. ST. LOUIS, Oct. 9 — That pale and trembling invalid, Mr. Babe Ruth, achieved something startling in the way of a convalescence out in the open air and summery sun glow this afternoon.

Three times he laid his crutch in the way and knocked the baseball out of the St. Louis ball park and finally, in the last half of the ninth inning, shook his groaning chassis into a wild loose-legged run to the rail of the temporary seats in left field, where he leaned over and plucked a foul ball out from the feathers on a lady customer's millinery for the final put-out of the World Series.

That was written by one of the best, Westbrook Pegler. But one story

'Rice, under deadline pressure, was trying to compose a march, not a minuet—it was a classic'

will of course not answer our inquiry. Nor will a day or two of reading old newspapers and anthologies. Still, one may tentatively hazard an opinion or two:

—If you add them up — Ring Lardner, Heywood Broun, John Kieran, Paul Gallico, Pegler and the rest — you may arguably conclude that there were more first-rate writers at work then than now.

—But the quality of sports writing in general was rather dreadful. Gee-whizzism was in flower. And there seemed to be a rule, unwritten but generally unbroken, that nothing could be called what it was. A base was a bag or a sack. A bat was a club or a mace. Metaphors were often painfully strained. There was an infatuation with inappropriate polysyllables. And copy was almost hopelessly congested with clichés that would be excised today by all but the most forgiving editors. There may be fewer certified whizzes these days, but there are happily fewer gee-whizzes.

Consider this 1928 masterpiece from The Times:

With the dazzling offensive play of Capt. Jack Bruner, Lowry McCaenlin and Jess Mortenson, Troy's three must-get-theirs on the basketball court, standing out like the proverbial sore thumb, Leo Calland's Southern California cagers swept to a 34-to-28 triumph over the Stanford quintet last night at the Trojan pavilion and climbed a notch closer to their first casaba championship.

Consider the soft but sure touch in these passages from a 1920 piece by Heywood Broun:

...It is also traditional that a distinct point shall be made of the fact that a large crowd was present. Of course, by this time there is probably no great element of surprise in that. If it were possible to say "only 10 persons witnessed the game between the Army and the Navy yesterday," that would be news and worthy of note. Still, there was a large crowd present. We counted up to 50,000 before the game began, but a few may have come in later....

And next a few lines by Irvin J. Cobb, who was sent by The New York Times to do a comprehensive account of the atmosphere and action at



the 1921 Dempsey-Carpentier fight. It was a long story, starting on page 1 and covering most of page 9, and Cobb was under pressure all the way, handing his copy to the telegrapher page by page.

...Conspicuous at the front, where the lumber-made cliffs of the structure shoal off into broad flats, is that type which is commonest of all alongside a fight ring. He is here in numbers amounting to a host. There must be thousands of him present. He is the soft-fleshed, hard-faced person who keeps his own pelt safe from bruises, but whose eyes glisten and whose hackles lift at the prospect of seeing someone else whipped to a soufflé. He is the one who, when his favorite pug is being hammered into a sanguinary Spanish omelet, calls out: "That's all right, kid, he can't hurt you." I see him countless repeated. For the anonymous youths who in the overtures are achieving still greater namelessness by being put violently to sleep, he has a listless eye. But wait until the big doings start. Then will his gills pant up and down as his vicarious lust for blood and brute violence is satisfied.

Newspaper editorials around the turn of the century had the delicacy of dynamite. Civilities were scrupulously disregarded. This bluntness also turned up occasionally on the sports pages, as illustrated by a 1908 New York Times piece that makes a baserunning error sound like an offense rising to the gravity of treason:

Did you hear about what old Young did up at the American League Park yesterday? He didn't exactly beggar description, but he came mighty nigh it. He beggared the Elberfield aggregation so far as runs were concerned, and he made hitless Yankees out of the whole outfit, and he smashed out singles thisaway and thataway, and he scored people that he liked, and he scored people that we don't know whether he cares much about or not, and he was the jolly old plot of the piece, and there wasn't an inning that you could lose track of him.

And even when breeziness gave way to bombast, the writer was sometimes kind enough to mix his excesses with occasional touches of comic invention. From the New York Times of 1920:

BOSTON May 1 — The Robins and the Braves celebrated May Day in this ordinarily peaceful city by staging a prolonged, heart-breaking struggle for 26 innings at Braves Field and bombing to bits all major

league records for duration of hostilities. When darkness drew its mantle over the scene, forbidding further battling, both teams were still on their feet, interlocked in a death clutch and each praying for just one more inning in which to get in the knockout blow.

As far as results in the chase for the pennant go the game was without effect, for the final score was 1 to 1. In the matter of thrills, however, the oldest man living can remember nothing like it, nor can he find anything in his granddad's diary worthy of comparison. Heart disease was the mildest complaint that grasped the spectators as they watched inning after inning slip away and the row of ciphers on the scoreboard began to slide over the fence and reach out into the Fenway. Nervous prostration threatened to engulf the stands as the 20th inning passed away in the scoreless routine and the word was passed from the knowing to those of inferior baseball erudition that the National League record was 22 innings....

Sometimes a writer would take a stab at poetry — and usually wind up with a self-inflicted wound. A 1928 dispatch to the Los Angeles Times began:

'There seemed to be a rule, unwritten but generally unbroken, that nothing could be called what it was'

CHICAGO, Feb. 4 (Exclusive) — Groaned Stoneham Charles to John McGraw:

"We have no star: the team won't draw;

"We're in for some rough goin'."

Purred John McGraw, "Don't be so glum

"A million fans shall surely come

"To see young Andy Cohen."

The New York Times deserved somewhat lower marks for its coverage of at least two other major events. On Oct. 2, 1932, the day Ruth supposedly called his shot in the World Series, no mention was made of his gesture until the 34th paragraph. Then, after taking note that the crowd had been getting on Ruth, the writer said:

A single lemon rolled up to the plate as Ruth came in the fifth and in no mistaken motions the Babe notified the crowd that the nature of his retaliation would be a wallop right out the confines of the park.

And in 1938, when a dying Lou Gehrig was honored at Yankee Stadium, it wasn't until the 24th paragraph that the New York Times man

got around to one of the most memorable quotes in American sports history:

...Today I think I'm the luckiest man alive.

But those last two specimens take us beyond the Golden Age. Let's get back to where we started, to Grantland Rice and probably the most famous story of all. Rice wrote it for the New York Herald Tribune one Saturday afternoon in 1924:

Outlined against a blue-gray October sky, the Four Horsemen rode again. In dramatic lore they are known as Famine, Pestilence, Destruction and Death. These are only aliases. Their real names are Stuhldreher, Miller, Crowley and Layden. They formed the crest of the South Bend cyclone before which another fighting Army football team was swept over the precipice at the Polo Grounds yesterday....

Judged by what it was supposed to be — and Rice, under deadline pressure, was trying to compose a march, not a minuet — it was a classic.

Even if Famine, Pestilence and Co. won by the rather underwhelming margin of 13 to 7.

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